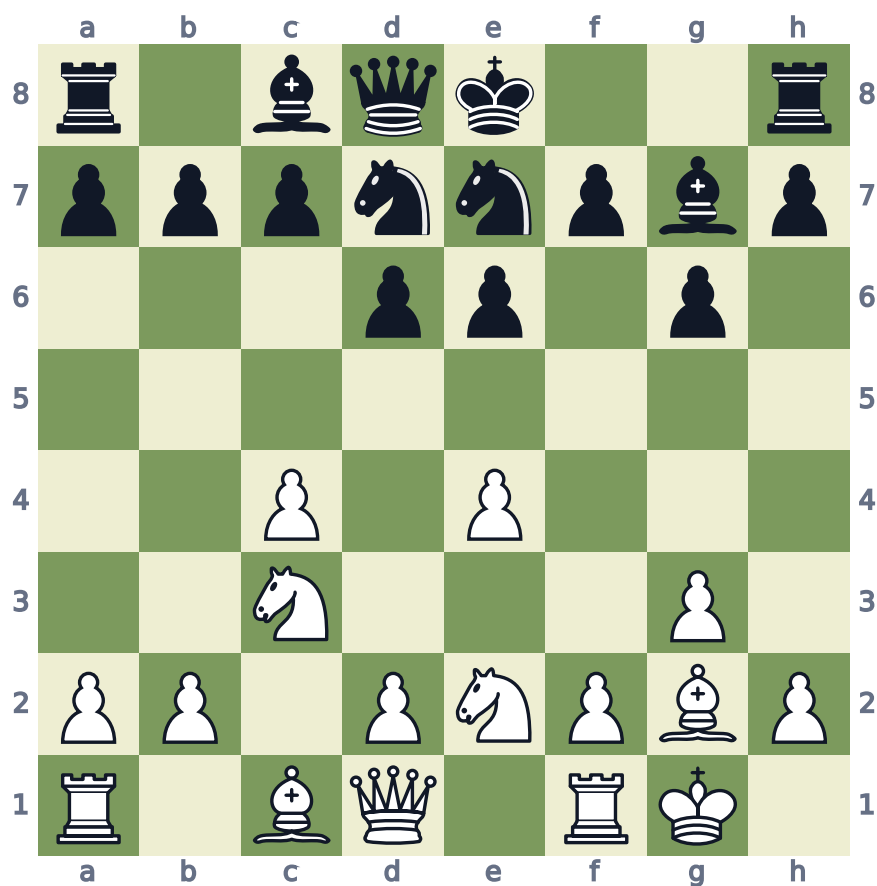


Hippo vs English, Reti, and Flank Openings

English structures, Reti development, Bird centers, and unusual first moves



Transpose intelligently against flank openings, preserving Hippo ideas while responding to structures rather than the opponent's first move.

8 learning units | solid-piece diagrams | recall tests | engine checks

ORIENTATION

How to study this volume

PURPOSE

Transpose intelligently against flank openings, preserving Hippo ideas while responding to structures rather than the opponent's first move.

THE HIPPO TRAINING LOOP

- First identify the center, both kings, and the opponent's most forcing pawn break.
- At every diagram, name the urgent threat and compare e5, c5, f5, and b5.
- Hide the answer until you have spoken the move, its purpose, and the opponent's best reply.
- Replay each branch from both sides in Fritz or another board program.
- Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.
-

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This volume contains 8 units inside a connected Black core repertoire. It teaches setup, exceptions, transformation, and resulting plans; the PGN companions make later updating possible.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 1-3

PRINCIPLE 1

A flank opening often transposes once White plays e4 or d4.

PRINCIPLE 2

Against an English setup, the d4 square and c5 break matter more than labels.

PRINCIPLE 3

Reti fianchettos make long diagonals a shared strategic resource.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 4-6

PRINCIPLE 4

Bird positions can become a reversed Austrian Attack with an extra tempo.

PRINCIPLE 5

Early b-pawn expansion is best answered by central occupation and development.

PRINCIPLE 6

The Hippo is optional when a direct central equalizer is stronger.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

REPERTOIRE MAP

Branches 1-8

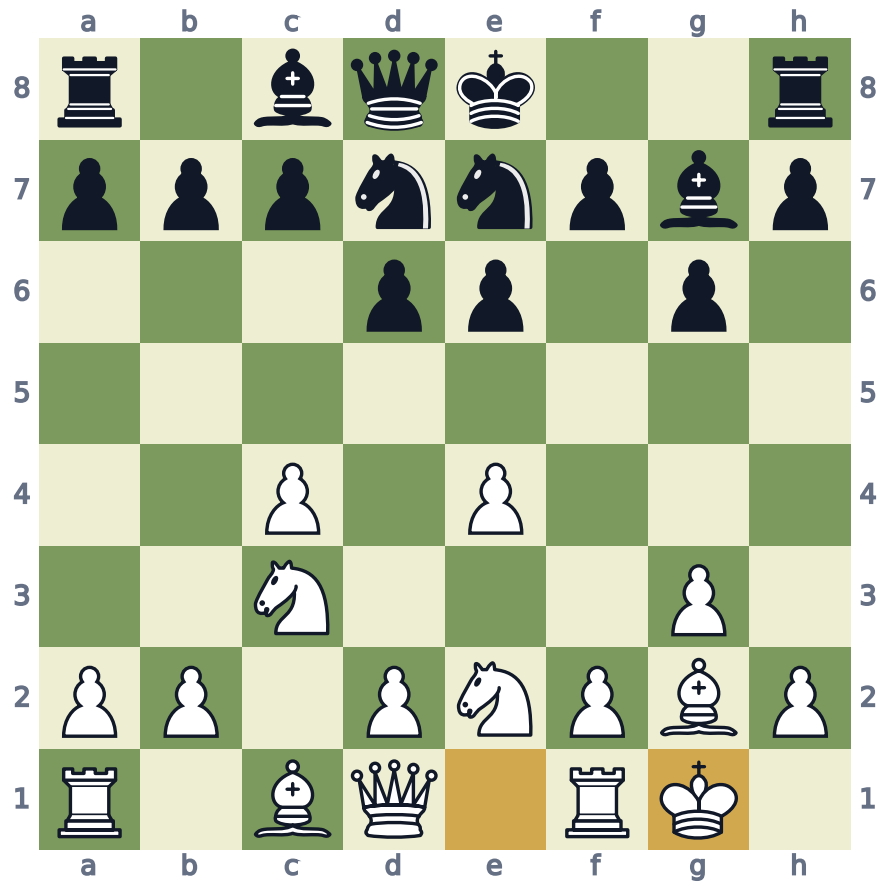
- | | | |
|-----------|-----------------------------------|---|
| 01 | English fianchetto | The English label disappears once e4 arrives; read the pawns. |
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 | | |
| 02 | Botvinnik English setup | Against pawns on c4 and e4, control d4 and identify the correct wing. |
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 | | |
| 03 | Reti with e4 | Transpose by position, not by the first-move name. |
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| 04 | King's Indian Attack shell | A quiet setup can hide a fast kingside plan; watch e5. |
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 | | |
| 05 | Bird Opening | Treat the Bird center as an e4 system with the f-pawn already committed. |
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 | | |
| 06 | Larsen Opening | Against b3, develop and make the center earn its space. |
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| 07 | Polish Opening | Wing expansion is answered first by center and development, then by pawn attacks. |
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 | | |
| 08 | 1.Nc3 transposition | The knight's first move removes ambiguity once e4 and d4 appear. |

NAVIGATION RULE

Identify the pawn structure first, then confirm the move order. A familiar position reached by a different sequence should trigger the same plan.

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 01

English fianchetto



COURSE LINE

1. c4 g6 2. Nc3 Bg7 3. g3 d6 4. Bg2 e6 5. e4 Ne7 6. Nge2 Nd7 7. O-O

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

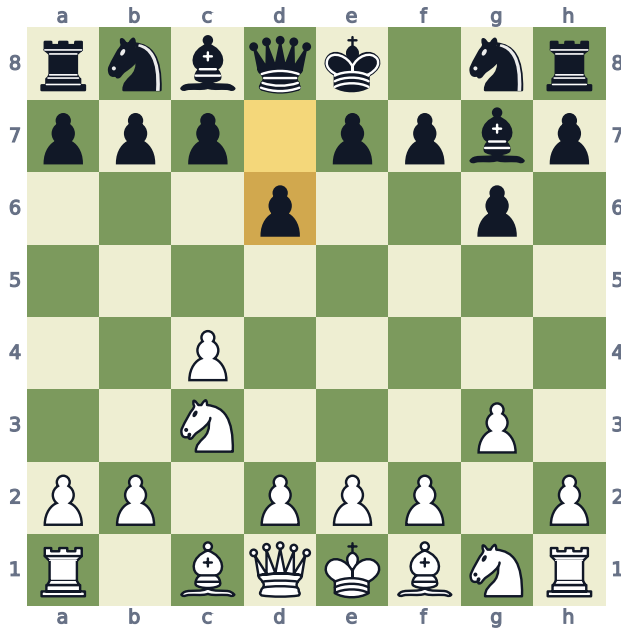
Transpose to a Hippo after White occupies e4 and prepare c5 or e5.

MAIN DANGER

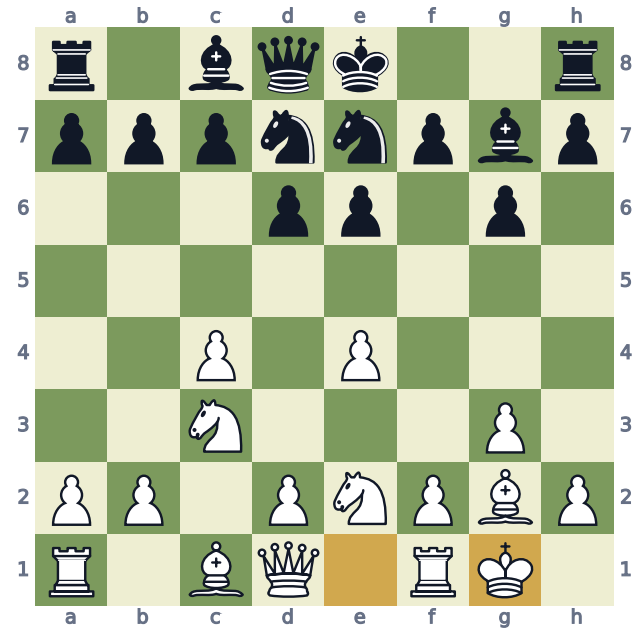
White can play d4 in one move and obtain a large center.

BRANCH LOGIC 01

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

The English label disappears once e4 arrives; read the pawns.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

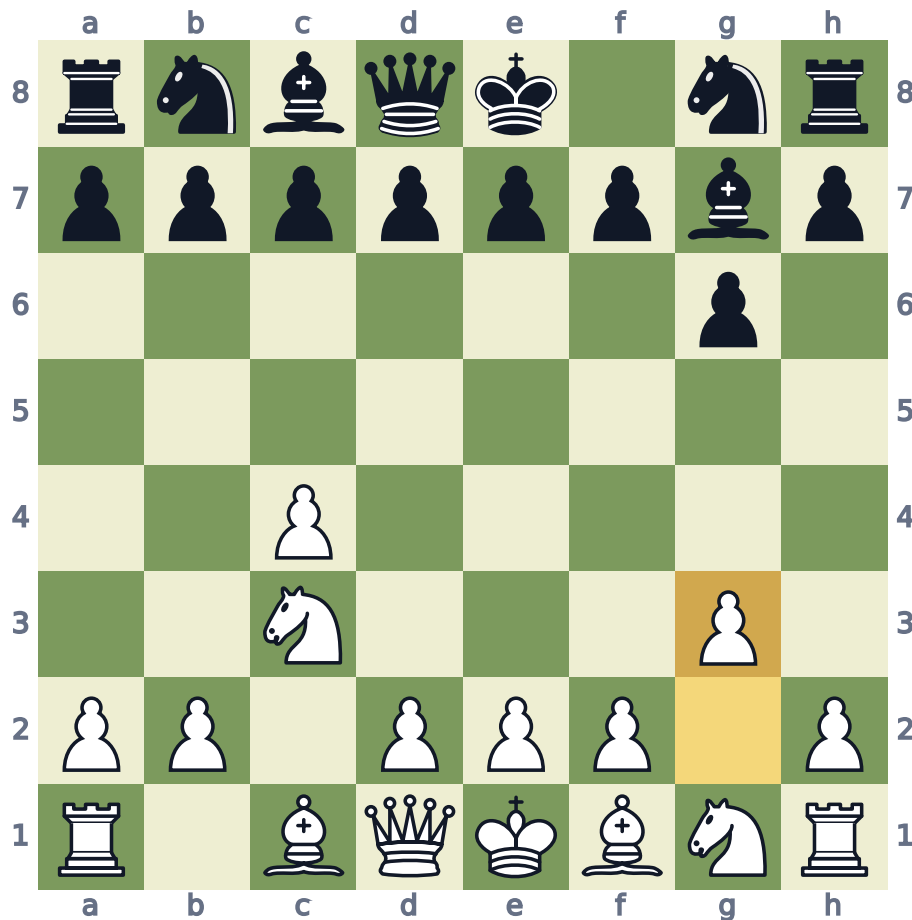
Position estimate: +0.62 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. a6 d4 2. Rb8 a4 3. O-O b4 4. Nc6 Rb1 5. e5 Be3

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 01

English fianchetto



YOUR TASK

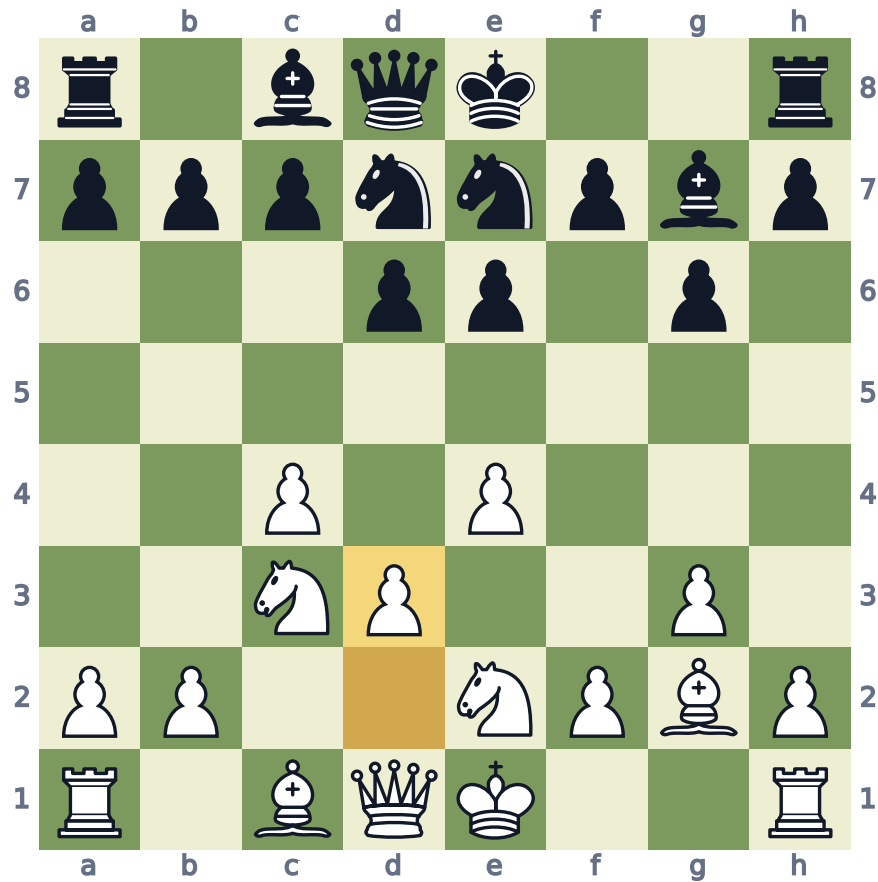
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 02

Botvinnik English setup



COURSE LINE

1. c4 g6 2. Nc3 Bg7 3. e4 d6 4. g3 e6 5. Bg2 Ne7 6. Nge2 Nd7 7. d3

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

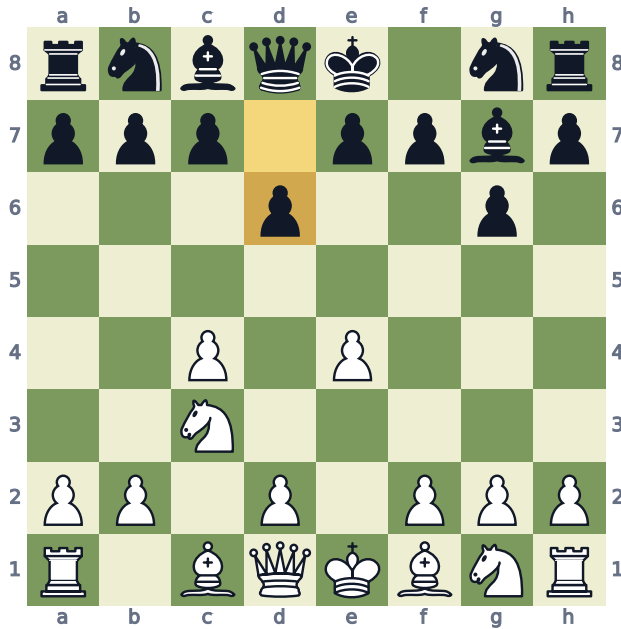
Restrict d4, develop compactly, and aim for f5 or c5.

MAIN DANGER

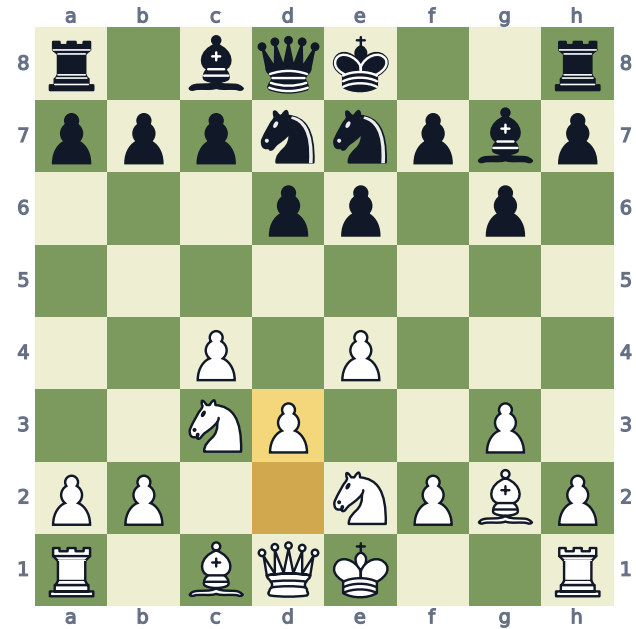
White may use f4-f5 with extra tempo.

BRANCH LOGIC 02

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Against pawns on c4 and e4, control d4 and identify the correct wing.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.26 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. a6 a4 2. c5 d4 3. cxd4 Nxd4 4. Qc7 O-O 5. Qxc4 Be3

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 02

Botvinnik English setup



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 03

Reti with e4



COURSE LINE

1. Nf3 g6 2. g3 Bg7 3. Bg2 d6 4. O-O e6 5. d3 Ne7 6. e4 Nd7

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

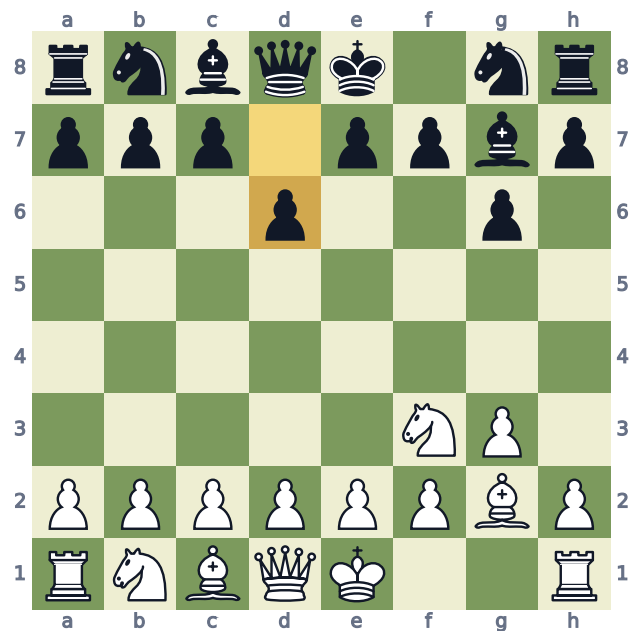
Maintain flexibility until e4 identifies a familiar Hippo center.

MAIN DANGER

d4 and c4 can still expand before Black makes contact.

BRANCH LOGIC 03

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Transpose by position, not by the first-move name.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

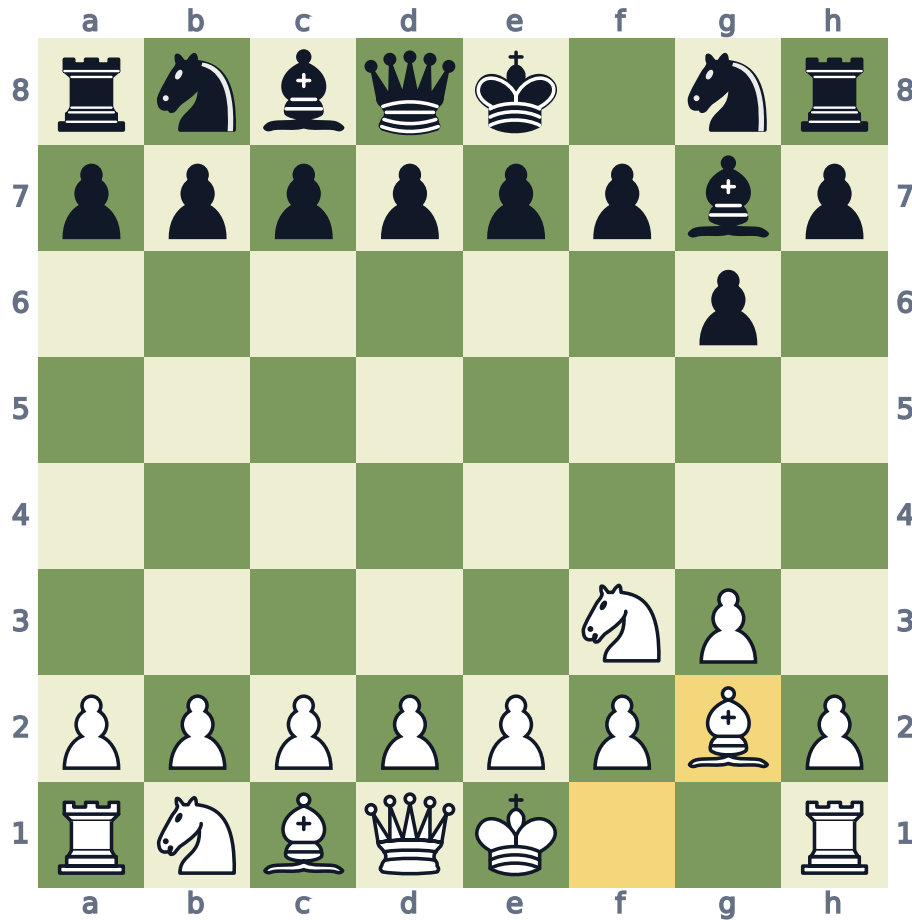
Position estimate: +0.48 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. a4 e5 2. Nc3 a6 3. Be3

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 03

Reti with e4



YOUR TASK

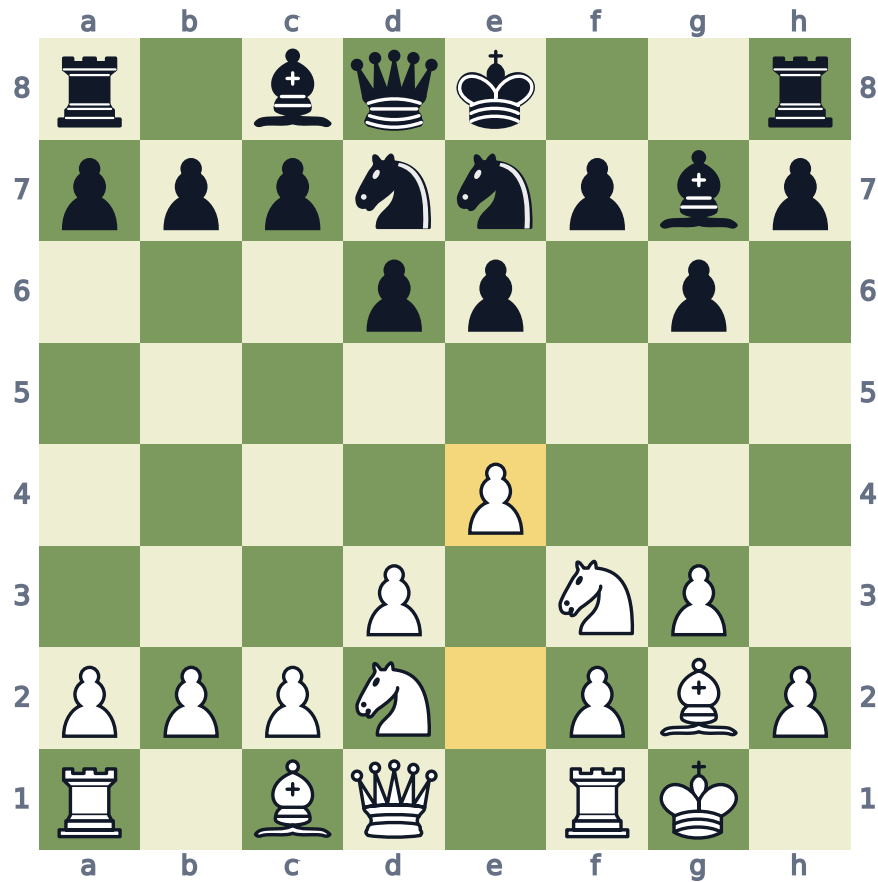
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 04

King's Indian Attack shell



COURSE LINE

1. Nf3 g6 2. g3 Bg7 3. Bg2 d6 4. O-O e6 5. d3 Ne7 6. Nbd2 Nd7 7. e4

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

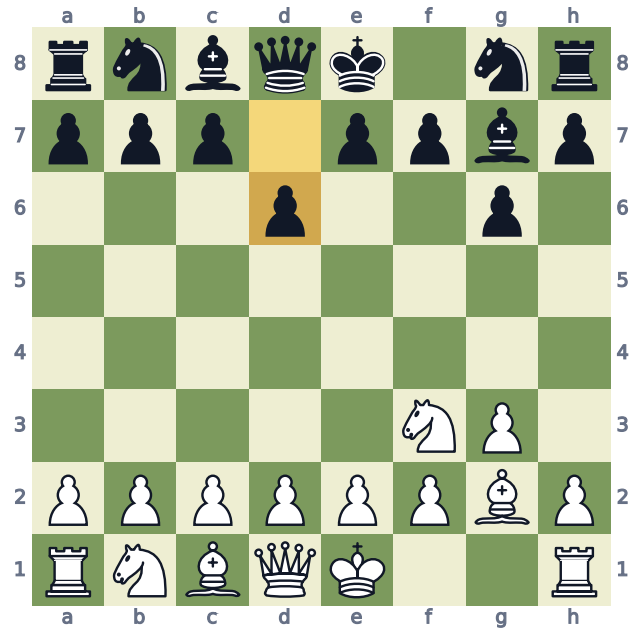
Use the extra central space before choosing e5 or c5.

MAIN DANGER

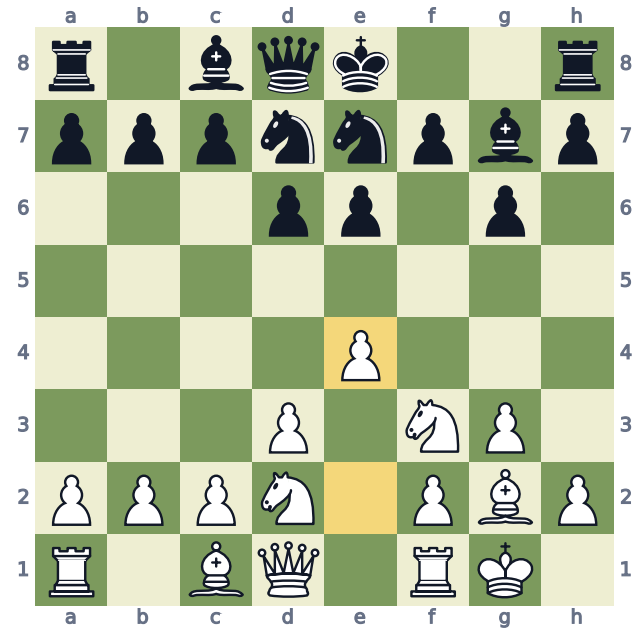
White's e5 and h4 attack can mirror dangerous anti-Hippo ideas.

BRANCH LOGIC 04

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

A quiet setup can hide a fast kingside plan; watch e5.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

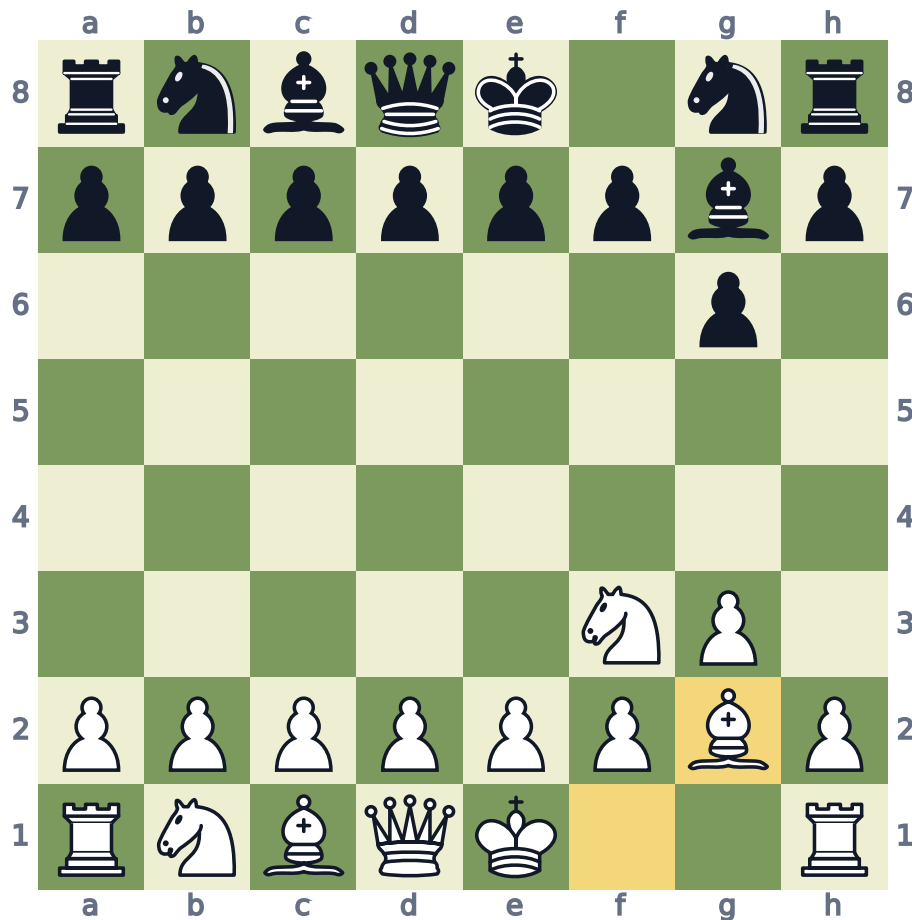
Position estimate: +0.31 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. b5 d4 2. O-O Nb3 3. a5 a4 4. b4 Re1 5. Nb6 c3

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 04

King's Indian Attack shell



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 05

Bird Opening



COURSE LINE

1. f4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. e4 d6 4. d4 e6 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O Nd7

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

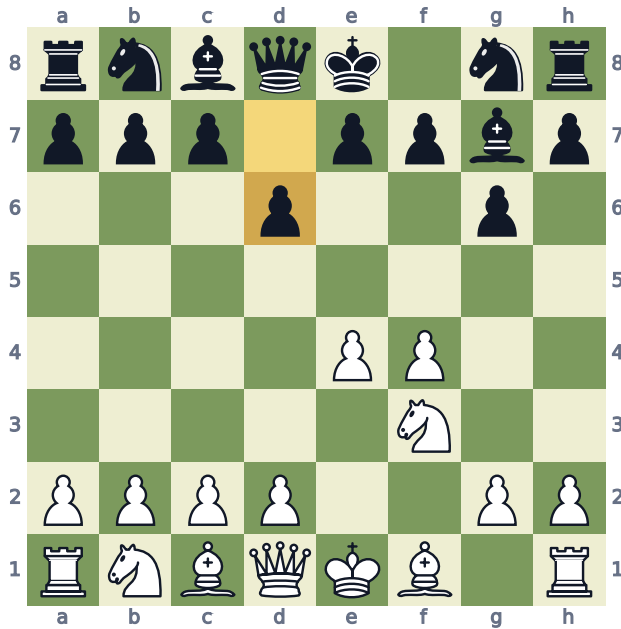
Target e4 and prepare f5 or e5 against the reversed Austrian center.

MAIN DANGER

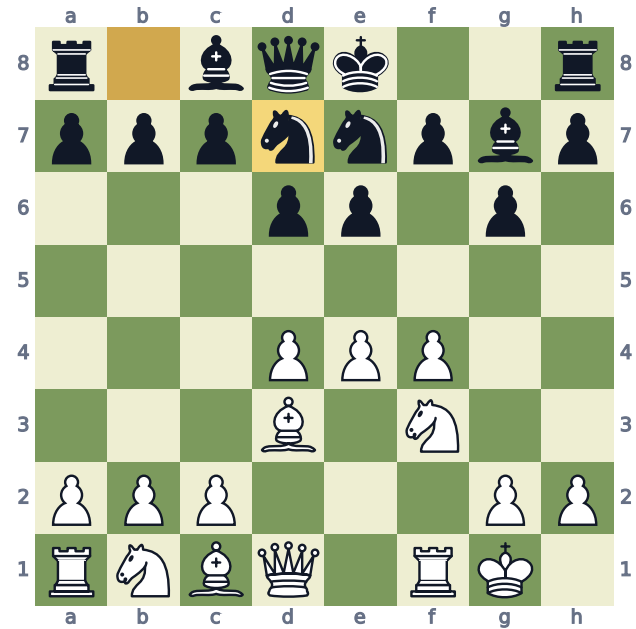
White's extra tempo supports e5 and f5.

BRANCH LOGIC 05

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Treat the Bird center as an e4 system with the f-pawn already committed.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.97 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. c4 O-O 2. Nc3 f5 3. e5 dxe5 4. dxe5 Nc5 5. Bc2 Nc6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 05

Bird Opening



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 06

Larsen Opening



COURSE LINE

1. b3 g6 2. Bb2 Nf6 3. Nf3 Bg7 4. g3 d6 5. Bg2 e6 6. O-O

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Occupy the center only after development clarifies White's plan.

MAIN DANGER

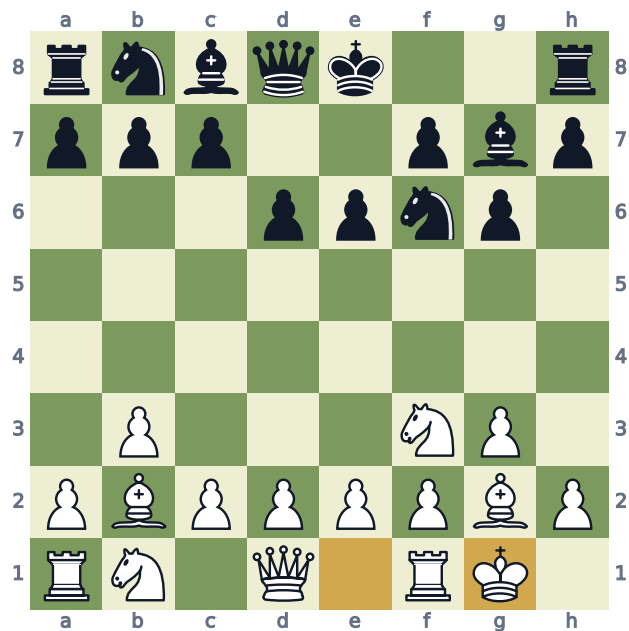
The b2 bishop can punish a careless e5 break along the diagonal.

BRANCH LOGIC 06

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 4 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Against b3, develop and make the center earn its space.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

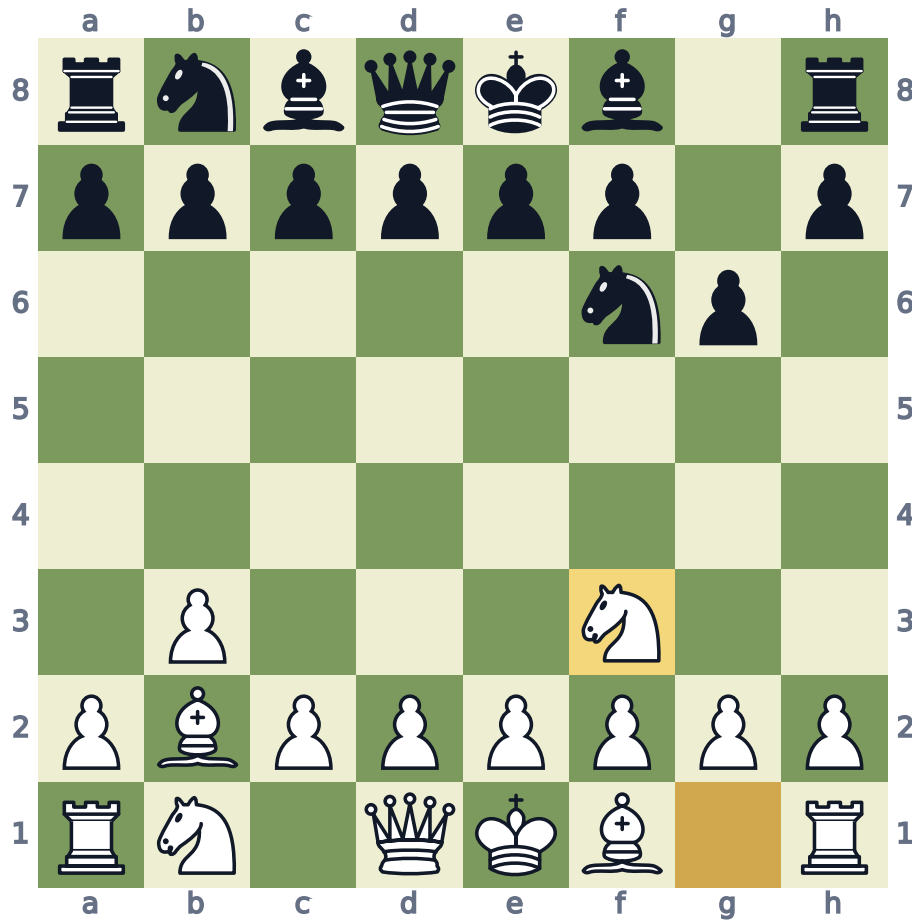
Position estimate: +0.18 for White (equal). Principal continuation: 1. e5 c4 2. O-O d3 3. Re8

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 06

Larsen Opening



YOUR TASK

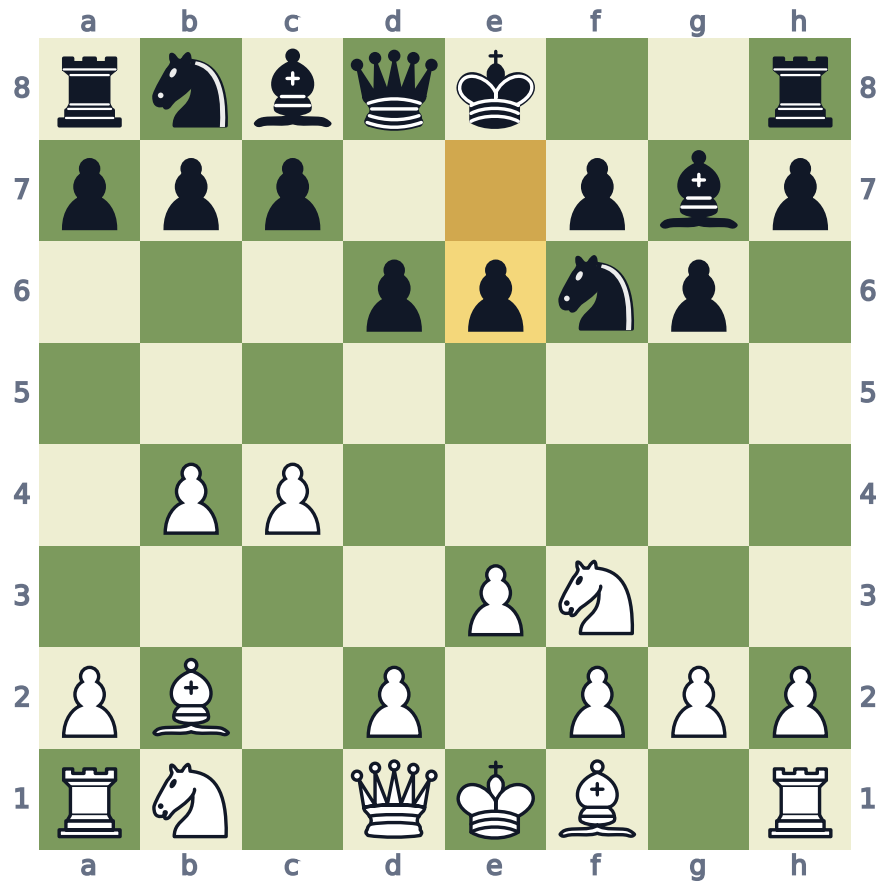
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 07

Polish Opening



COURSE LINE

1. b4 g6 2. Bb2 Nf6 3. Nf3 Bg7 4. e3 d6 5. c4 e6

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

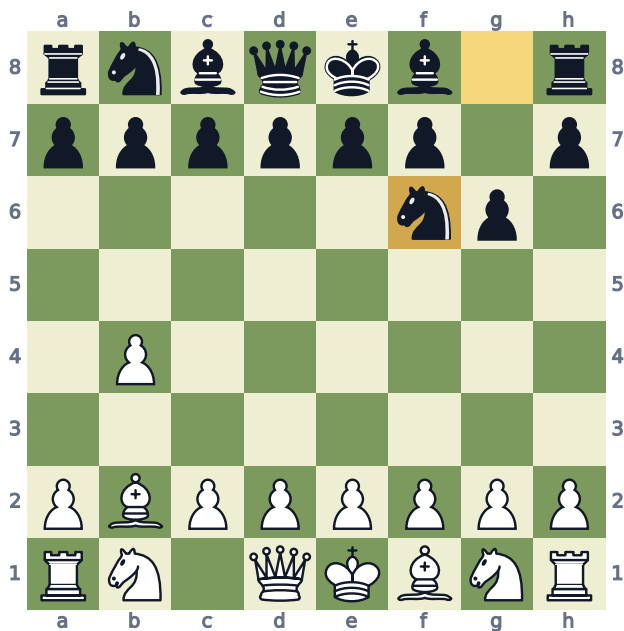
Develop, attack the advanced b-pawn later, and keep central options open.

MAIN DANGER

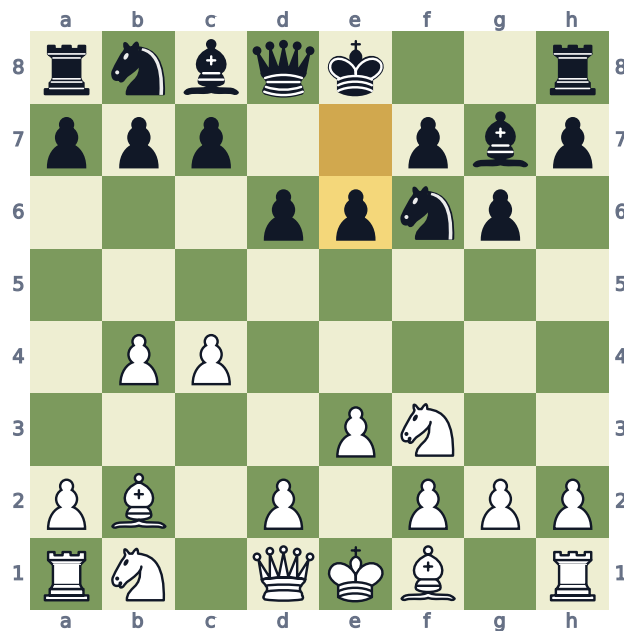
b5 can gain space and restrict c6 before Black is ready.

BRANCH LOGIC 07

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 4 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Wing expansion is answered first by center and development, then by pawn attacks.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

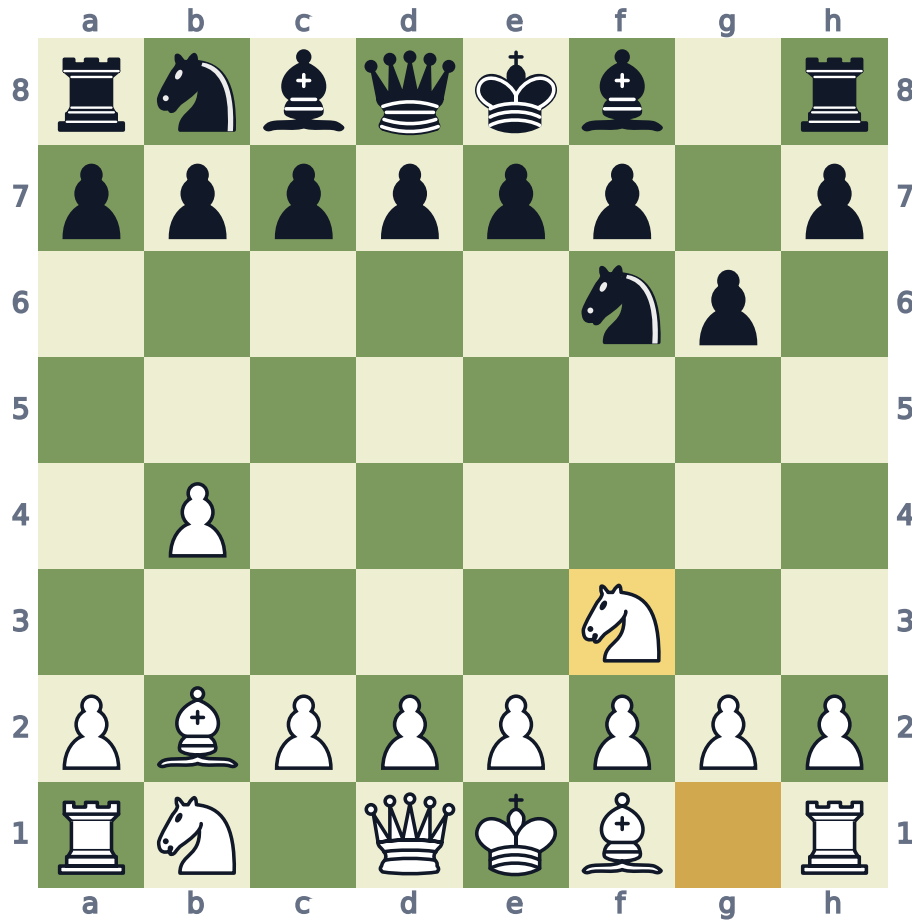
Position estimate: +0.35 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Be2 Qe7 2. d4 O-O 3. O-O b6 4. Nc3 Bb7 5. b5 a6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 07

Polish Opening



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 08

1.Nc3 transposition



COURSE LINE

1. Nc3 g6 2. e4 Bg7 3. d4 d6 4. Be3 e6 5. Qd2 Ne7 6. O-O-O

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

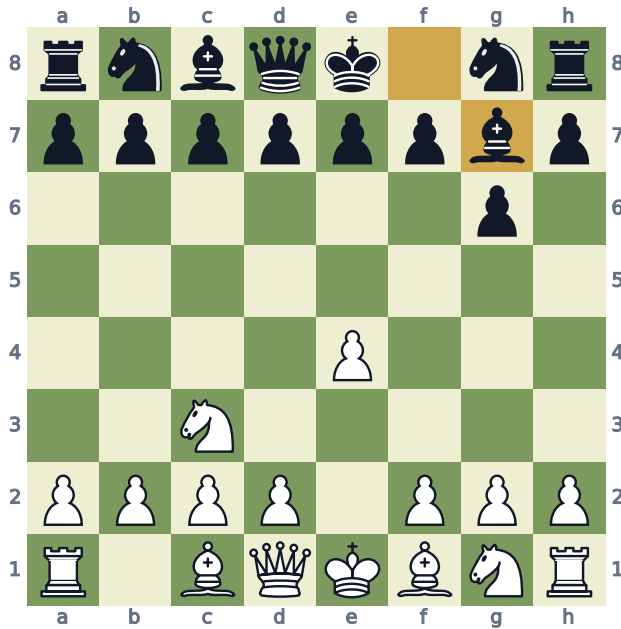
Recognize the 150 Attack structure and keep the king flexible.

MAIN DANGER

h4-h5 can open lines rapidly.

BRANCH LOGIC 08

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 4 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

The knight's first move removes ambiguity once e4 and d4 appear.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.22 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. h5 f4 2. d5 Nf3 3. dxe4 Nxe4 4. Nd7 Bd3 5. b6 Ne5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 08

1.Nc3 transposition



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

ANSWER SECTION

Recall solutions begin here

PROTECT THE TRAINING EFFECT

Do not read a solution until you have committed to a move and purpose. A matching move without the correct reason earns partial credit. If the course move is not the engine's first choice, compare plans rather than treating the engine as a memorization oracle.

ERROR LABELS

M = move-order memory | T = tactical oversight | P = plan misunderstanding | V = visualization | C = calculation | R = rushed recognition

REPAIR RULE

Every miss must produce a question you can use in future games. Example: 'When Black supports d5 with c6, which pawn break or recovery method does my repertoire use?'

SOLUTIONS

Answers 1-3

01. ENGLISH FIANCHETTO

Course move: d6. Purpose: Transpose to a Hippo after White occupies e4 and prepare c5 or e5. Engine comparison: 1. e5 Nf3 2. Nc6 Bg2 3. Nge7 d3 4. O-O O-O 5. d6 Rb1 (+0.20 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: White can play d4 in one move and obtain a large center.

02. BOTVINNIK ENGLISH SETUP

Course move: d6. Purpose: Restrict d4, develop compactly, and aim for f5 or c5. Engine comparison: 1. c5 g3 2. a6 d3 3. Nc6 Bg2 4. b5 Nge2 5. Rb8 O-O (-0.29 for White (Black is slightly better)). Warning: White may use f4-f5 with extra tempo.

03. RETI WITH E4

Course move: d6. Purpose: Maintain flexibility until e4 identifies a familiar Hippo center. Engine comparison: 1. d5 d4 2. Nf6 c4 3. dxc4 Qa4+ 4. c6 Qxc4 5. a5 O-O (+0.17 for White (equal)). Warning: d4 and c4 can still expand before Black makes contact.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 4-6

04. KING'S INDIAN ATTACK SHELL

Course move: d6. Purpose: Use the extra central space before choosing e5 or c5. Engine comparison: 1. d5 d4 2. Nf6 c4 3. dxc4 Qa4+ 4. c6 Qxc4 5. a5 O-O (+0.17 for White (equal)). Warning: White's e5 and h4 attack can mirror dangerous anti-Hippo ideas.

05. BIRD OPENING

Course move: d6. Purpose: Target e4 and prepare f5 or e5 against the reversed Austrian center. Engine comparison: 1. c5 Nc3 2. Nc6 a4 3. a6 Bc4 4. e6 O-O (-0.04 for White (equal)). Warning: White's extra tempo supports e5 and f5.

06. LARSEN OPENING

Course move: Bg7. Purpose: Occupy the center only after development clarifies White's plan. Engine comparison: 1. Bg7 e3 2. c5 Be2 3. Nc6 c4 4. O-O O-O 5. d5 cxd5 (+0.08 for White (equal)). Warning: The b2 bishop can punish a careless e5 break along the diagonal.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 7-8

07. POLISH OPENING

Course move: Bg7. Purpose: Develop, attack the advanced b-pawn later, and keep central options open. Engine comparison: 1. Bg7 e3 2. O-O d4 3. d6 Be2 4. Nd5 a3 (+0.08 for White (equal)). Warning: b5 can gain space and restrict c6 before Black is ready.

08. 1.NC3 TRANSPOSITION

Course move: d6. Purpose: Recognize the 150 Attack structure and keep the king flexible. Engine comparison: 1. d6 Nf3 2. Nf6 Be3 3. O-O Qd2 4. c6 Bh6 5. Bg4 O-O-O (+0.67 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: h4-h5 can open lines rapidly.

VOLUME REVIEW

Make the repertoire usable

REVIEW TASK 1

Reconstruct every branch from the first move without looking.

REVIEW TASK 2

For each branch, explain one Black plan and one White plan.

REVIEW TASK 3

Shuffle the recall positions so the chapter title cannot reveal the answer.

REVIEW TASK 4

Play each starting position against Fritz from both sides.

REVIEW TASK 5

Add mistakes from your own games to the PGN as new training positions.

REVIEW TASK 6

Retest the weakest three branches after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.

GRADUATION STANDARD

Score at least 80 percent twice, one week apart, and explain every move in plain language. Then maintain the volume through your own games instead of rereading it continuously.